How should we think about the introduction of strategy/outcomes diagrams into planning work ('shared thinking tools')?

Adopting an extensive and disciplined use of DoView strategy/outcomes diagrams involves a paradigm shift. This shift finds support from the area of strategy psychology. Strategy psychology asks the question: 'From a psychological point of view, what is the most efficient way to do planning, implementation, and reporting?'

Strategy psychology views strategy, implementation, and measurement work as a set of distributed decision-making problems. Doing this work involves a large number of different individuals in advising on, making and implementing strategic decisons.

How can strategy psychology help us optimize strategy development and implementation? Drawing on cognitive psychology, it seeks to minimize problems arising from built-in psychological constraints on how individuals take in, overview, and process information. From a social psychology point of view, it focuses on how groups can best communicate strategy, make collectively-informed decisions, and faithfully implement strategy.

A key concept in strategy psychology is 'cognitive load'. This is the amount of mental processing that individuals at all levels within the strategy and implementation system have to do to understand a strategy problem, make decisions about it, and then act. Strategy and implementation work has a high cognitive load when just using traditional text-and-table documents and verbal discussions.

Recent work in strategy psychology highlights the fact that strategy and related problems should be thought of as examples of ´shared cognition.´ This is the idea that those involved are not just a group of individuals separately working things out and then talking about them with others. Instead, the whole process is seen as a shared decision-making process from the start to finish.

Within a shared cognition framework, DoView drill-down strategy/outcomes diagrams are seen as 'shared cognition artifacts' or 'shared thinking tools'. They are things in the outside world, external to people's brains, which they use to 'think together' as they work on a problem.